was a proud and yet a very humbling occasion when I was adorned with the rank badges of a four-star general by my parents and my wife, Rohini, on Monday, 31 January 2005. I happened to be the twenty-fourth chief of army staff since independence.

Our great army has been carefully nurtured by many illustrious predecessors and placed on a solid foundation of nationalism and the three pillars of being *apolitical, secular and professional*. Our ethos and traditions flow from these fundamentals. What would be my mission and key objectives during my tenure of two years and eight months as the army chief or the 'Jangi Laat,'[2] a term used by some elder veterans while addressing the chief? This thought was uppermost in my mind as I set about shouldering the responsibilities of my office. In fact, this process started as soon as I was nominated in November 2004 itself.

> An Army is to a Chief what a sword is to a soldier.
>
> – Marshal Foch: Precepts, 1919

I defined my aim in simple and precise terms – to lead the second-largest army in the world, a highly professional force that should be optimally trained, equipped and structured. The army should have the capability to operate successfully in a joint services environment in the entire spectrum of conflict in a network-centric battlefield. And, if and when challenged, our motto shall be – 'Fight to Win.'

Calling on President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and Defence Minister Pranab Mukherjee were my first few important engagements. I accepted their congratulations and the discussions that followed were brief, formal and cordial. I assured them that I would do my best in the service of the nation, and give the Indian Army the leadership that the officers and the men expected of their chief. The next on my agenda was to visit J&K, the northeast and the sensitive border areas, and observe things first hand. Travelling in the comfort of the Boeing executive jet of the IAF's VIP Squadron gave me time to think about and refine my ideas.